While all this was going on, Dutchman and fellow coach Mike Minnaar had disappeared off to the bladdy horse races. And, as luck would have it, they returned to the ground just in time to see me go out to the biggest slog ever. When I got back to the changing room, Dutchman laid into me: ‘What the fuck do you think you’re doing? This is four-day cricket – you can’t just play these huge, big fucking hoicks like that!’ I just laughed. I mean, the guy had gone off for a quick gamble, had missed the 160-odd runs Bleekie and I had put on, and had then given me a lecture on how *I* should be approaching the game!

But that was part and parcel of the team spirit in that squad back then. It was really fantastic. You couldn’t help but be a little naughty. Even a guy like Gary Kirsten had his moments, let me tell you. There was this game we played in Queenstown – a one-dayer, I think. I was 16, and it was one of the first nights Gary and I ever went out together. I know Gary still remembers that evening very well, and I must add that this happened way, way before Gary met his wife Debbie!

So, anyway, we meet this gorgeous brunette and we’re both very keen on her. I mean, *very* keen. Somehow we ended up back at her place – well, her folks’ place, actually, but they weren’t there – and we were all a little tipsy. The girl seemed up for a little fun, but Gary and I couldn’t work out which one of us she liked more. It looked like we were both in the game. While she was off somewhere else in the house, Gary and I met up in the kitchen.

‘What do you think we should do, man?’ he asked. ‘Do you want to go for her?’ In a moment of consideration for my fellow teammate, I remember saying, ‘No, you’re older than me. You might as well go for it.’ So Gary got the girl and I went back to the hotel for a cold shower. That evening was the start of what would not only become a successful opening partnership on the field, but also a valuable friendship off it.

Ja, those were really happy days. Everything was so new, fresh and exciting, I could barely sleep at night. Former Proteas bowler and later coach, Eric Simons, will testify to that. He was my first roommate at Province. I used to wake up at around 6 a.m. and open the curtains, switch on the TV – M-Net was still pretty new then – and generally make a racket. Poor Eric is 12 years older than me and needed a few more hours’ sleep. Even today I don’t need more than a six-hour kip.

I look back on those days with a lot of nostalgia. Those first few years were filled with laughter and naughtiness – hardly surprising, given the